

Emma Cunningham, Brady Cross

Delegation from Allied Gardens, San Diego

The Republic of Latvia

United Nations Environment Assembly

The Disproportionate Impact of Climate Change on the Global South

Section I

Climate change affects all countries, but the impacts affect the Global South more. For example, rising sea levels affect island nations in the south, food insecurity affects lower-income countries, displacement due to weather affects the south a lot, and poverty affects the whole south. While there are treaties to try to stop climate change causes like fossil fuels, many countries are not meeting the goals. For example, the Paris Agreement is an agreement to limit global warming from fossil fuels, and each country has goals based on its development and financial capabilities.¹

Rising sea levels are affecting countries that are either surrounded by ocean or have a large border with the ocean. China, Bangladesh, India, Australia, and the Pacific islands are some of the countries most at risk². Rising sea levels cause flooding, coastal erosion, and flooding of deltas.³ Flooding would affect not only human life, but also affect wildlife both on beaches, and the water. Not only that, but flooding also greatly affects humans directly through property damage, health risks from the water, housing displacement, and crops and livestock loss.⁴ All of this places great economic strain on the Global South, further driving poverty. Coastal erosion is when flooding, waves, and rising sea levels slowly take away from the land. The rising sea levels take away sand, rocks, and soil to the ocean, cutting down the land piece by piece.⁵ Flooding of deltas is expected to happen more often due to climate change, and coastal flooding, because of rising sea levels and climate change. This has a great effect on wildlife and populations near rivers.⁶

¹ <https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-paris-agreement/the-paris-agreement>

² <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2022/09/rising-sea-levels-global-threat/>

³ <https://www.c2es.org/document/sea-level-rise-global-climate-change-a-review-of-impacts-to-u-s-coasts/>

⁴ <https://ecology.wa.gov/Air-Climate/Responding-to-climate-change/Flood-impacts>

⁵ <https://toolkit.climate.gov/topics/coastal-flood-risk/coastal-erosion>

⁶ <https://beta.nsf.gov/news/study-shows-coastal-flooding-will>

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Food insecurity is caused by climate change through droughts, heat waves, and heavy rainfall. All the effects of the disasters caused by climate change ruin the crops, so people have less, and have to put more money toward the crops. Because of this, food becomes more expensive, causing about 30 million people in low-income areas to experience food insecurity.⁷ Food insecurity is related to poverty because people that already struggle to pay for food are even further affected by poverty when food insecurity becomes more intense.⁸ About 1.5 billion people are multidimensionally poor, as of 2022, including 593 million children under 18.⁹ Food insecurity causes illnesses because hungry people are affected by diet-related chronic diseases more than others.¹⁰

Climate change is causing the weather to be more extreme in the Global South, forcing many people to leave their homes in search of safety. An average of about 21.5 million people have been displaced every year, since 2008.¹¹ In 2023, that leads to about 322.5 million people. This causes people to lose all their possessions and leads to people being unemployed in a new country. This leads to poverty, and possibly hunger.¹² Looking at 2021 statistics, China had the most people displaced due to disaster, with 6.04 million. India, Indonesia, and the Philippines were also greatly affected.¹³ This shows how largely populated countries are being affected greatly.

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<https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/feature/2022/10/17/what-you-need-to-know-about-food-security-and-climate-change>

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https://hungerandhealth.feedingamerica.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/Food-Insecurity-Poverty-Brief_2018.pdf

⁹ <https://hdr.undp.org/content/2022-global-multidimensional-poverty-index-mpi#/indicies/MPI>

¹⁰ <https://www.feedingamerica.org/hunger-in-america/impact-of-hunger>

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<https://www.zurich.com/en/media/magazine/2022/there-could-be-1-2-billion-climate-refugees-by-2050-here-s-what-you-need-to-know>

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Although the effects seem unstoppable, the United Nations has resolutions in place to slow the effects. Not only that, but many countries are also getting involved. The most notable and known agreement is arguably the Paris Agreement, by the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), an agreement that aims to stop climate change, with each country having its own goals. The agreement works in 5-year intervals, with the country's goals getting more ambitious every time.¹⁴ The UNFCCC has an annual Conference of the Parties (COP) where the parties are represented at a different location every year, and currently are on their 27th.¹⁵ At each conference, the parties discuss their progress toward goals for climate change and discuss how to combat climate change.¹⁶ The main goals are to stop burning fossil fuels. When fossil fuels are burnt, carbon dioxide and methane are both released into the atmosphere. Those molecules both trap heat, causing climate change.

Section II

Latvia produced 0.02 percent of all carbon dioxide emissions for 2021.¹⁷ Even more impressively, their greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions went down 8.33% from 2020 to 2021.¹⁸ This is important because it shows that Latvia is focusing on its emissions about GHG and is trying to lower it. Latvia may not support many efforts to combat climate change, instead they lower emissions on their own.¹⁹ For example, they are one of the top eco-friendly countries in the European Union, with

¹⁴ <https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-paris-agreement/the-paris-agreement>

¹⁵ <https://unfccc.int/process/bodies/supreme-bodies/conference-of-the-parties-cop>

¹⁶ <https://unfccc.int/blog/everything-you-wanted-to-know-about-cop-but-were-afraid-to-ask>

¹⁷ https://edgar.jrc.ec.europa.eu/report_2022

¹⁸ <https://www.statista.com/statistics/411343/total-indexed-greenhouse-gas-emissions-in-latvia/>

¹⁹

https://www.climate-laws.org/legislation_and_policies?from_geography_page=Latvia&geography%5B%5D=96&type%5B%5D=executive

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only 6 tonnes of GHG/per capita.²⁰ Latvia also went down from a whopping 7.1 metric tons of carbon dioxide emissions to 4 from 1990 to 2019.²¹

Latvia is also greatly affected by climate change. Latvia has had its precipitation go up by 39 mm since 1961, greatly affecting its beaches.²² Latvia is the third most affected country by climate change in the European Union, after Finland and Lithuania.²³ Climate change is also greatly affecting the forests in Latvia, through heavy and intense storms, and an increase in the number of pests.²⁴ These effects not only put wildlife at risk but also put the natural beauty of the country at serious risk. In 2010, Latvia's forests extended over 57% of the land. In 2021 it lost about 48,400 hectares of forest land.²⁵ Although Latvia does recognize the problems that climate change brings, the government does not have the flexibility to aid the Global South, receiving aid themselves recently.

Section III

Although the problem is still raging on, The Delegation of Latvia believes that there are some solutions. The Delegation of Latvia has some ideas on how to lower the number of carbon emissions even more in Latvia. Also, The Delegation of Latvia thinks that The Delegation of Latvia has an idea of how countries can financially aid the Global South, and finally, how other countries can lower emissions.

Although Latvia produced only a small amount of GHG emissions, their emissions can be even less. Although in 2021 Latvia was mostly carbon neutral, gas still was 38.4 percent of their energy.²⁶ The Delegation of Latvia believes that if the country benefits companies that lower this

²⁰ <https://www.greenmatch.co.uk/blog/2018/07/top-eco-costly-countries-in-eu>

²¹

https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/EN.ATM.CO2E.PC?contextual=default&end=2019&locations=LV&most_recent_value_desc=false&start=1990&view=chart

²² <https://climate-adapt.eea.europa.eu/en/countries-regions/countries/latvia>

²³ <https://www.greenmatch.co.uk/blog/2019/04/climate-change-europe>

²⁴ <https://www.lvm.lv/en/news/5624-how-climate-change-affects-latvia-s-forests>

²⁵ <https://www.globalforestwatch.org/dashboards/country/LVAMap=true>

²⁶ <https://www.statista.com/statistics/1236343/latvia-distribution-of-electricity-production-by-source/>

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amount, more will be inclined to help. The benefits could include paying for half of the company's expenses for the creation of carbon-neutral energy, like solar energy plants and wind farms. Also, the Latvian government could give those companies (such as SIA Intergaz and Olimps²⁷) support by using their energy if they are the first to lower the number of fossil fuels by 10 percent. They could use their energy in all government buildings, such as police offices, hospitals, fire departments, and government buildings. This was, companies will be eager to hit this goal because of the benefits that come afterward.

Countries in the Global South are more at risk of the effects of climate change than the countries in the Global North, as stated previously. The Global North is more developed than the Global South, and the effects of climate change on the Global South are worsening that difference. Because the Global North has access to more resources and is wealthier, The Delegation of Latvia believes that some support to the Global South, which has less money and resources is due. The amount of financial aid given to a country could be directly based on its economy and its budget annually. For example, the United States spent 6.27 trillion dollars in 2022²⁸ compared to a Global South country like Indonesia which spent \$29.77 billion.²⁹ This shows the true difference in spending that countries have in the two regions. The Delegation of Latvia believes that 0.4% of a country's budget can be used to financially aid countries in the Global South, from the developed countries in the Global North. 0.4% of a budget may seem like a lot, but this is to help millions if not a billion people fight against the results of climate change. Before a country gives its cut to a Global South country, the UN can ask for details and make sure that everything goes right. The Delegation of Latvia chose to use percentages so that every country is in an equal situation. This could be enforced by the

²⁷ <https://www.lusha.com/company-search/oil-energy/68/latvia/117/>

²⁸ <https://fiscaldata.treasury.gov/americas-finance-guide/federal-spending/>

²⁹ <https://www.reuters.com/markets/asia/indonesias-2022-unaudited-budget-deficit-238-gdp-finmin-2023-01-03/>

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United Nations, but tell the developed countries how to aid the Global South, or what countries to specifically aid.

Other countries can enforce the slowing of fossil fuel consumption by funding the creation of carbon-neutral power sources. For example, in Mississippi, the United States government can fund a hydropower plant to gain electricity from the Mississippi river. Or, wind farms near San Francisco or Boston, very windy cities that could benefit from more wind electricity.³⁰ For countries such as Norway, it may benefit them to fund more solar power plants, seeing Norway is where the sun goes the longest without setting.³¹ There are more ways to produce carbon-neutral energy, but it truly depends on where the plant is located. The Delegation of Latvia believes that countries could put aside 0.5% of the annual budget toward funding the creation of new power plants. Countries already very reliant on clean energy, such as Latvia, may need to reduce the amount of funding that is put aside for the creation of these plants. The United Nations could ask for progress reports every 3 months and check-ins when necessary, or the is suspected to be lying.

³⁰ <https://www.currentresults.com/Weather-Extremes/US/windiest-cities.php>

³¹ <https://www.visitnorway.com/things-to-do/nature-attractions/midnight-sun/>

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Worldwide, pharmaceutical companies are producing millions of medicines each day. In the process of production, chemicals are released into their surrounding environment and into ecosystems. These chemicals are called Environmentally Persistent Pharmaceutical Pollutants (EPPPs). The residues from production make their way into rivers, lakes, and other bodies of water. Not only do EPPPs come from production, but veterinary medicines are in manure, which is also used as fertilizer, contaminating the soil. Human waste provides the perfect transportation of EPPPs to wastewater. Overall, EPPPs are moving from different sources to new areas creating a domino effect, and making their appearance almost everywhere. In these areas where EPPP concentration is higher, they are producing new species of microbes that become resistant to the chemicals in the medicines. This is called Anti-Microbial Resistance (AMR). AMR lowers the effectiveness of the current medicines, making them no longer work.

Anti-Microbial Resistance has consistently been a main topic in the World Health Organization for the past two decades. The World Health Assembly has adopted multiple resolutions and continues to track progress because AMR is one of the largest threats to our advances in medicine. In 1998, the World Health Assembly (WHA) created Resolution WHA 51.17: Emerging and Other Communicable Diseases: Anti-Microbial Resistance. During the WHO June 2000 Geneva consultation, WHO came up with a strategy for the containment of Anti-Microbial Resistance. This contains recommendations for reducing the incorrect use of

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antimicrobials, including education in hospitals on usage, personal and food hygiene, and keeping resistance reports.

At the 54th World Health Assembly in 2001, two AMR resolutions were established. First, WHA 54.11; WHO's medicine strategy. Resolution WHA 54.14 focused on Global Health Security; Epidemic Alert and Response.

During the 2005 58th World Health Assembly, resolution WHA 58.27 Improvement of Anti-Microbial Resistance was created. This resolution asked for support from the Director-General for ample support and supply to pick up the pace on resolutions WHA 51.17 and WHA 54.14 on containing anti-microbial resistance. In the same year, resolution EB120.R12 was passed to set up a plan for the rational use of drugs worldwide. These were both a substantial part of the 2007 progress report on technical and health matters, WHA A60/28.

By the year 2011, the AMR situation was at large. The 2011 World Health Day sponsored by the World Health Organization (WHO) was themed on anti-microbial resistance (AMR) to raise awareness of the issue. The World Health Organization published Options for Action; The Evolving Threat of Anti-Microbial Resistance, in 2012. Alongside, a global action plan (GAP) on Anti-Microbial Resistance. The Global Action Plan includes 5 main goals. (1) One Health, a plan that involves multiple committees because AMR affects everyone. (2) Sanitation, in order to prevent infection to lessen the need for treatment. (3) Equitable access for

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everyone. (4) Ensuring every country has a National Implementation Plan (NIP). (5) Developing proper targets for implementation.

In May 2014, WHA 67.25 was published. Again, focusing on Anti-Microbial Resistance. Over the years, in 2015, 2016, and 2021 multiple global action plans were created and revised for AMR. Finally, in 2019, resolution WHA 72.5 was implemented, once again accelerating and adding to the process of combating AMR.

In 2019, Latvia published a National Action Plan (NAP) available in the World Health Organization's library of anti-microbial resistance national action plans. In June of 2022, the Ministry of Health Republic of Latvia published *Latvia's Experience on AMR Policy Development*. This contains goals for the 2023-2027 period which is essentially the next set target for their National Implementation Plan. The main points mentioned in the document were important international documents, most importantly the *European Union (EU) One Health Action Plan Against AMR* released in 2017, the 2023-2027 AMR action plan, policy objectives, and common objectives.

The framework of the action plan is based on the European Union's (EU's) One Health AMR Action Plan published in 2017. The first key objective was to make the European Union the best-practice region in controlling the spread of AMR. To do this, they needed the second key objective which is boosting research, developing solutions and technology, and implementing of

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the new findings from research. Finally, just to boost EU efforts worldwide on the global AMR agenda.

In the 2023-2027 action plan, Latvia's Ministry of Health identified their unfulfilled actions for 2019-2020 and moved them to the next planning period (2023-2027). The next part of the action plan mentions LATOHOP- a project led by the Swedish Board of Agriculture and the Public Health Agency, the project provides tools and newer ways of communication between parts of Latvia to fight AMR as a country. This section of the action plan discusses the proposals within the groups in LATOHOP for AMR resources and prioritizing measures. Not only are there proposals from LATOHOP in the action plan, but they are also taking approaches from experts, such as a proposal for the establishment of a competence center in the field of public health.

Section II

The goal of the upcoming/current action period regarding the policy was to (1) Encourage controlling the spread of AMR, leaving the need for organizations and governments to work together and (2) promote responsible use of antimicrobials, changing the way they are currently used in human and animal health. The new objectives included monitoring the use of antimicrobials in hospitals by keeping data and surveillance in order to control the spread of diseases. Prevention and control are especially important for diseases such as

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Multidrug-Resistant Tuberculosis (MDR-TB), which is spread through bacteria and affects the lungs.

Not only are veterinary and human hospitals a part of controlling the spread, but so are institutions. Pharmacies and other institutions involved with medicine must cooperate in collecting data and slowing the spread of disease through surveillance, data keeping, and proper sanitation. Funding should be more towards the creation of AMR research laboratories to gain a better understanding of the antimicrobials. The Ministry of Health promotes research in environmental and health areas and hopes to create a method for tracking anti-microbial resistance in bodies of water where they are highly popular. Finally, to get the country working together, the people must be a part of the process, not just the professionals. Education in the proper use of antibiotics for the general public is extremely important because they are the majority of the people using antibiotics and spreading antimicrobial resistance.

Section III

The Delegation of Latvia proposes a solution to enhance research and education for the general public. Most anti-microbial-resistant bacteria grow in bodies of water such as rivers and lakes. Latvia contains many rivers and small lakes including the Daugava River, Lielupe River, the Gauja River, Lake Burtnieks, Lake Lubans, and Pape Lake. Using 10 million dollars funded by WHO's core voluntary contributions (CVC), at each body of water, an AMR research laboratory would be constructed. To gain awareness of the general public, the l

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laboratories would be open for field trips three days a week with tours and mini-lectures led by NGO volunteers from Alliance to Save Our Antibiotics, Health Care Without Harm Europe, and Patients' Organizations "Together With You" which are all award-winning NGOs for their contributions to the AMR cause. On one day of the weekend, business dinners could be held at a waterfront venue near each laboratory where the business would discuss their tasks, or whatever they were there for. A few of the scientists working in the lab would be responsible for informing the attendees at the dinner a little bit about the research they do, what AMR is, and what the average person can do to help. If the solution is successful, similar laboratories and activities involving the general public would be then implemented in countries in the EU, and possibly worldwide.

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